

passage of the sun through four cardinal signs, the relations between the company's solstice and mine. "Even if a company has a good aspect, that doesn't mean it's going to work out for you to own it," he said. "Some people aren't cut out for owning stocks at all. Their charts show that clearly. If they buy something—no matter how positive it is—some hitch will occur and they will lose money."

I doubted that this research would be worth the trouble, especially after Mr. Attride said he couldn't do it gratis. Also, I dreaded hearing that my cosmic alignments were unsuited to any and all investing, which I feared, given the earthly results, would be his astrological conclusion. I confessed this fear, and also asked Mr. Attride if he couldn't recommend a less rigorous and hopefully cheaper advisor. He recommended Mr. Arch Crawford.

He said Mr. Crawford wasn't so much an astrologer as he was a student of the ionosphere. He'd heard that Mr. Crawford published an investment newsletter that gave stock market advice based on atmospheric conditions.

I met Mr. Crawford in a swank little cappuccino shop called Sacco's at Seventy-seventh Street and Lexington Avenue. He was 10 minutes late, which he blamed on the "options closing at 4:10 and the futures at 4:15." He wore wire-rimmed glasses, corduroy pants, a button-down blue shirt, and sported a goatee. He had the red hair and fair skin of an Appalachian, the crumpled look of a Brooks Brothers academic, and he spoke with a subtle, professorial Southern drawl.

He said he'd studied math and physics at the University of North Carolina. Then, in 1963, he'd gone to work with Robert Farrell, the famous Merrill Lynch technical analyst. "I was marking a chalkboard at Merrill Lynch, putting up the stock prices. This was before the days of electronic scoreboards. Then Merrill Lynch sent me to night school, and I came back to help Mr. Farrell with his charts. Charting was thought of as witchcraft on the Street at the time, but now it's gotten quite respectable. So has Mr. Farrell."

Mr. Crawford, meanwhile, went to Vietnam, returned to New York in 1969 to trade his own account, and made and lost two personal fortunes. Somewhere in the middle he'd discovered the electrical forces in the atmosphere. He also discovered that he did